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‘THE THREAT IS SO REAL’

By Lisa Schencker
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The last thing Chelsea Cheveria remembers after the birth of her daughter was greeting her new baby girl. “I said, ‘Hi, oh, that’s my baby,’” Cheveria, 38, recalled. She kissed the tiny newborn, and her husband told her, “You did it.”

Then everything went dark. Without warning, Cheveria’s heart stopped as she lay atop the operating table where minutes earlier doctors had delivered her baby Zairah through a cesarean section.

Workers rushed her husband Scott Cheveria out of the room, and doctors and nurses began performing CPR on the Logan Square mom. A medical worker urged Scott Cheveria to pray, he said.

“We were all smiles and everything was going well,” said Scott Cheveria, 39,

Chelsea Cheveria’s heart stopped after giving birth. Now, she’s warning others about blood clots during pregnancy

Above: Chelsea Cheveria holds her newborn daughter, Zairah, on Wednesday at their home in Chicago’s Logan Square neighborhood. After giving birth in February, Cheveria developed blood clots in her lungs that sent her into cardiac arrest and was saved by medical staff at Northwestern Medicine Prentice Women’s Hospital. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

remembering that day. “And then the tables turned and everything became a nightmare.”

Now, 12 weeks later, the family is home and, miraculously, healthy. They’re celebrating their first Mother’s Day as a family of four after what doctors describe as a rare but life-threatening pregnancy complication.

Chelsea Cheveria had developed a blood clot that traveled through her heart and to her lungs, known as a pulmonary embolism. The clot obstructed the flow of blood out of her heart, causing her blood pressure to plummet and cardiac arrest.

Though only about one in 1,000 pregnant women develop pulmonary embolisms, it’s one of the most common causes of pregnancy-related death in the U.S.

Though blood clots can happen during pregnancy, for someone to go into cardiac arrest because of one “is quite rare,” said Dr. Daniel Schimmel, director of the Pulmonary Embolism Response Team

See **CLOTS** on Page A5

Millions in COVID dollars returned

Health department voluntarily gave money back to government

By Alice Yin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Throughout last year, Mayor Brandon Johnson vowed to protect Chicago’s public health dollars from President Donald Trump.

But behind the scenes, his health commissioner voluntarily returned tens of millions of dollars in COVID-19 grants to the federal government months before expiration — funds that could have gone to disease surveillance to help prepare for an outbreak or racial equity programming to improve health outcomes across the city.

Commissioner Dr. Olusimbo Ige also terminated over two dozen Chicago Department of Public Health employees last fall despite Johnson emphatically drawing a line against layoffs and his Law Department successfully fending off threats from the White House to slash Chicago’s federal funding thus far. Her actions unfolded alongside investigations of a hostile work environment and significant turnover among her employees.

The outcome was self-inflicted, said a former CDPH epidemiologist who was let go in December and has filed pending retaliation and disability discrimination complaints against Ige.

“Sometimes I’ve lost belief in the system,” Hannah Matzke told the Tribune. “I’m so disheartened because these are people who should know better, and do know better. ... I don’t know how long Dr. Ige will be the commissioner, but I am afraid that she’s making decisions that impact (CDPH) long term.”

In a statement on Friday, Ige defended her handling of the personnel cuts by saying she wanted to “coordinate” the department’s transition off multiple COVID grants, some of which did expire last year, with one restructuring that “prioritized core functions.”

“I managed a department during

See **MONEY** on Page A6

INSIDE



JULIO CORTEZ/AP

Not an arms race

As win streak ends at 10, the Cubs feel no urgency to add a starting pitcher, despite social media madness. **Paul Sullivan in Sports**

Ceasefire tested

The U.S. strikes on Iranian tankers on Friday cast doubt on the ceasefire, but the U.S. says it’s still in effect. **Nation & World, Page B5**

Once centers of teen culture, many malls take last breath

Formerly quintessential shopping complexes may be past their prime

By Audrey Pachuta
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Storefronts once crammed with shoppers, now covered by tarps. Flickering lights. Sweatpants-clad mall-walkers with nothing to look at and nowhere interesting to stop.

A man takes off one shoe, then another, and reclines in a lifeless wing of Ford City Mall. He props his bare feet up on a nearby chair. “What?” he said. “Who’s gonna stop me here?”

Such is the last breath of another dying mall.

A few decades ago, massive buildings, like Ford City on Chicago’s Southwest Side, were rife with crowds of loitering teenagers who spent hours mingling in arcades and food courts. Much like their youthful, emotional heartbeats, malls in the ’80s and ’90s bustled, becoming as quintessential to American culture as hot dogs and apple pie.

Today’s teens have no shortage of movies and TV shows romanticizing what malls were like in their parents’ youth. Look no further than the opening sequence in “Fast Times at Ridgemont High” or Regina George summoning her fellow Plastics with the line “Get in loser, we’re going shopping” in “Mean Girls.”

Across Chicagoland, malls memorialize “the good old days.”

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A mall walker rests at a sparsely populated Lincolnwood Town Center on April 30. The Village Board and property owners recently agreed to a phased demolition of the mall as part of a predevelopment plan.

E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

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